

Expressive Meaning and Emotional Valence

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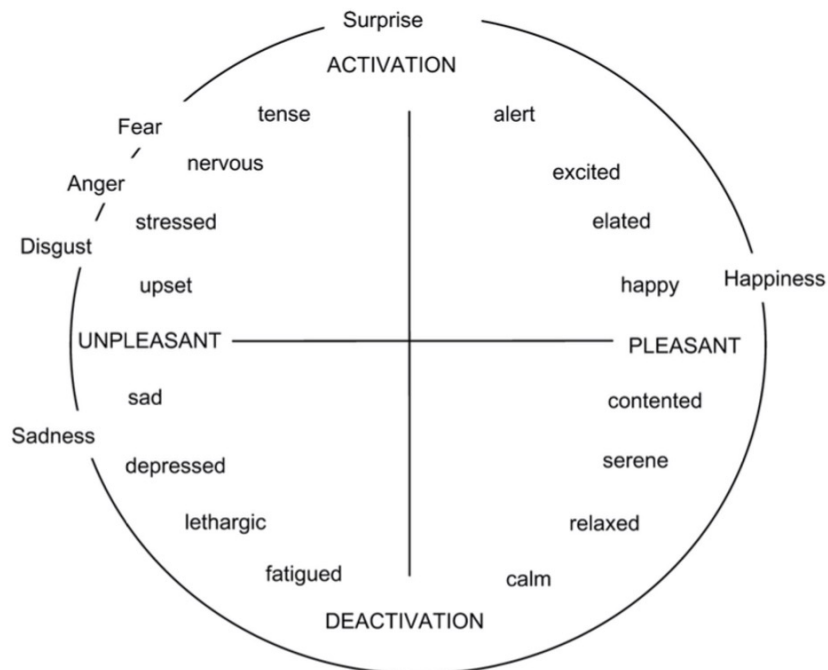
Background

Expressive Meaning

- Use-conditional meaning expressing a speaker attitude (e.g., Kaplan, 1999; Potts, 2007; Gutzmann, 2015 Gutzmann, 2019)
 - (1) The waiter has spilled the coffee.
 - (2) The waiter has spilled the damn coffee.

Emotional Valence

- Affective value of a stimulus on a positive to negative continuum (e.g., Osgood et al, 1959; Cacciopo et al., 1997; Barrett, 2006)
- Primary component of dimensional emotion models (e.g., Russell, 1980, Mehrabian, 1996; Warriner et al., 2013)



'Circumplex Model of Affect' (Russel, 1980)

Motivation for Valence-Based Approach

- Builds on existing research while offering key advantages
 1. Vague emotion related description
 - ‘Heightened emotional state’/‘Negative Speaker attitude’ (e.g., Potts, 2007; Gutzmann, 2019; Bross, 2021, Domaneschi et al. 2025)
 2. Discrete meanings of same valence polarity
 - Expressive full stops as ‘annoyance’, ‘insincerity’, ‘hostility’ (e.g., Gunraj et al., 2016; Houghton et al., 2018; Albritton, 2022)

Research Questions

1. Expressive meaning as a conventionalized non-at issue valence appraisal
2. Defining expressive meaning via valence-appraisal patterns
3. Influence of contextual emotion cues on semantic behavior of expressives

RQ1:

Expressive Meaning as Valence Appraisals

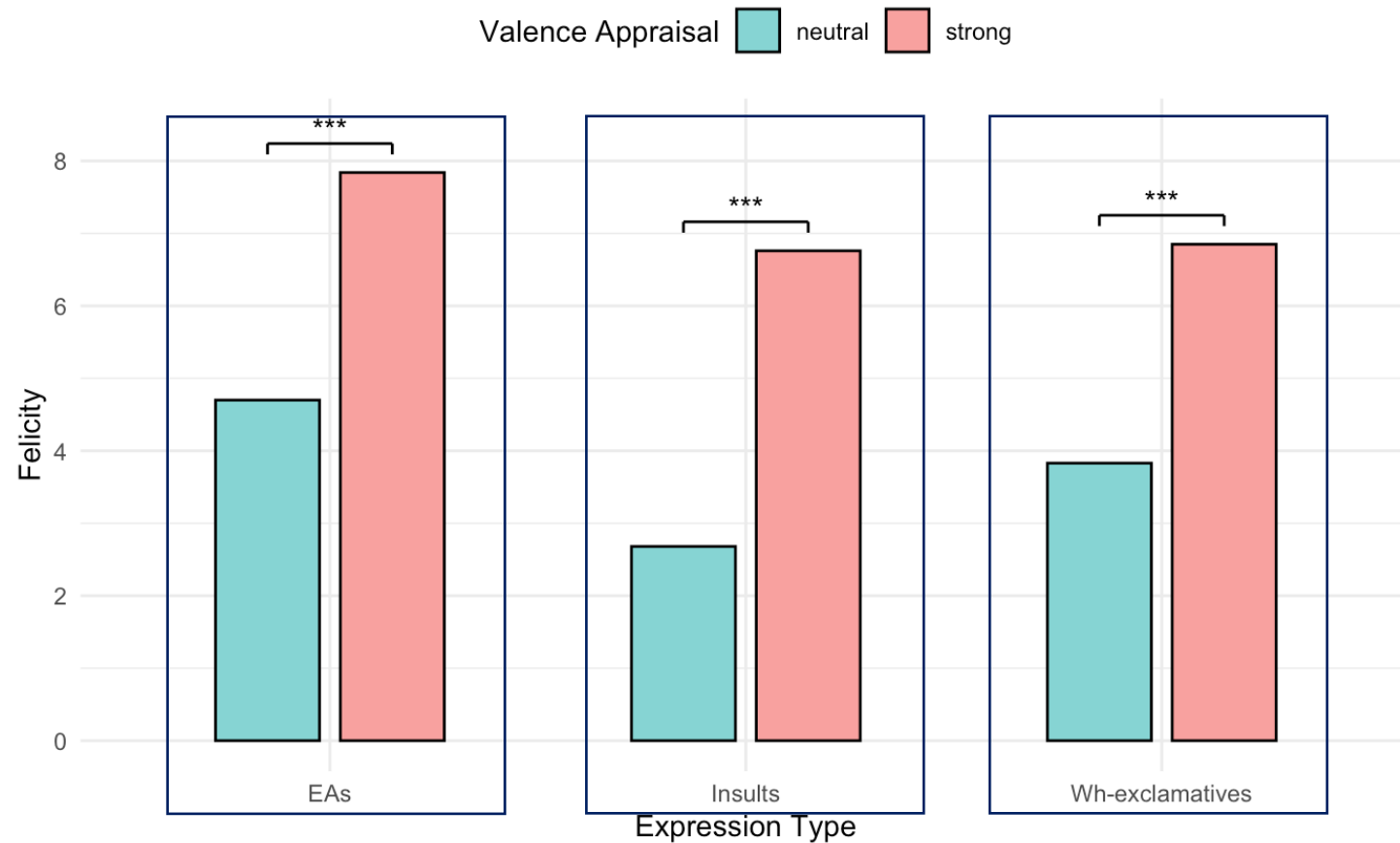
Testing Felicity of Expressives

- **Prediction:** Infelicity of expressives in contexts denying strong valence appraisal
- **Measure:** Acceptability ratings of expressives following contexts manipulated for valence appraisals

(4) Jens [feels neutral|very negative] about the waiter. He says,

- a) “The damn waiter is over there!” (Paper 1, Study 1)
- b) “The jerk Peter is over there!” (Paper 6, Study 1)
- c) “What a waiter!” (Paper 4, Study 1)

Felicity of Expressives



RQ2:

Valence Appraisal Patterns of Expressive Meaning

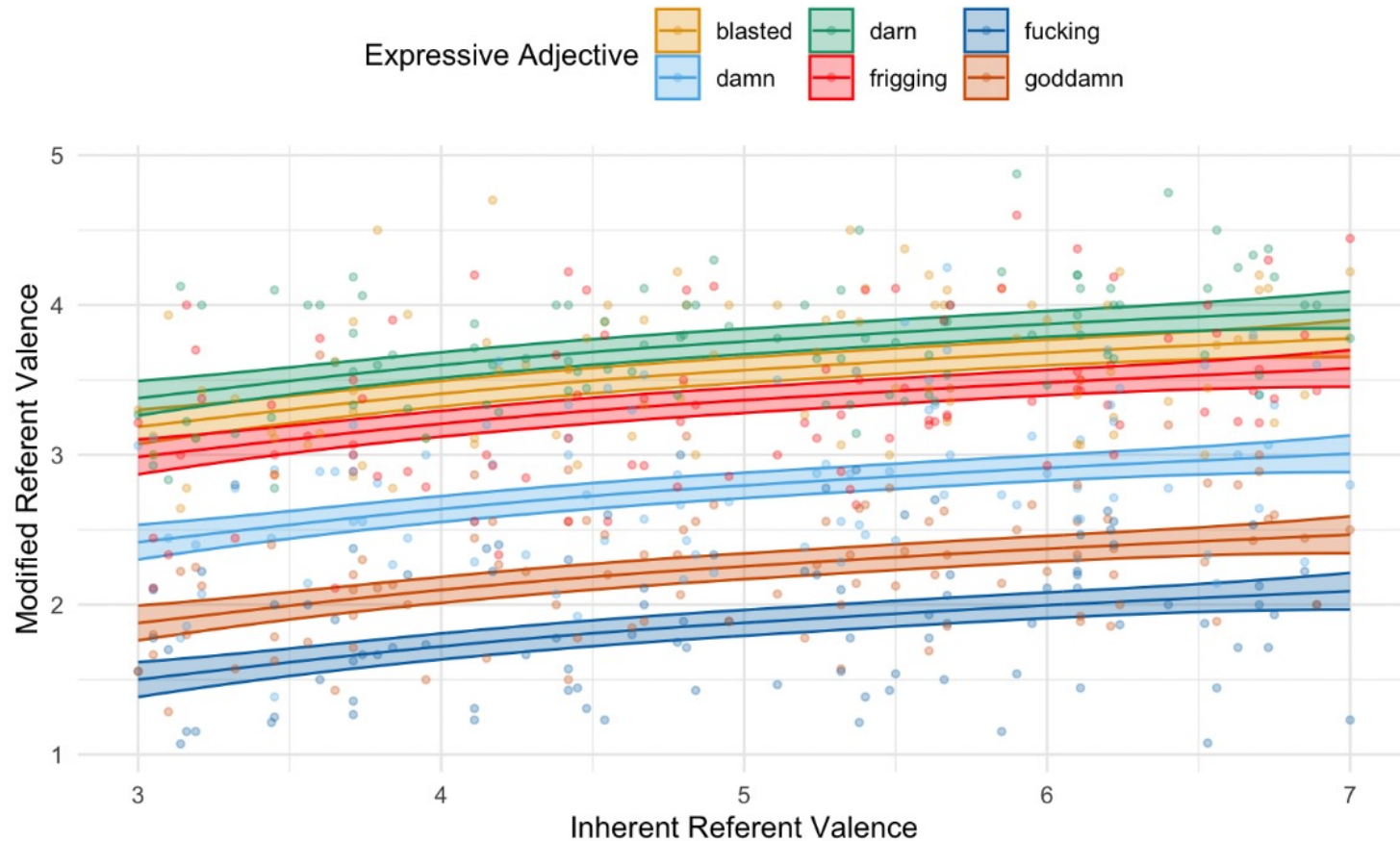
Expressive Valence Appraisal Patterns

- **Prediction:** Expressive expressions function as linguistic valence setters
- **Measure:** Comparison of valence of discourse referents before and after application of expressive element (Warriner et al. 2013; Mohammad 2018)

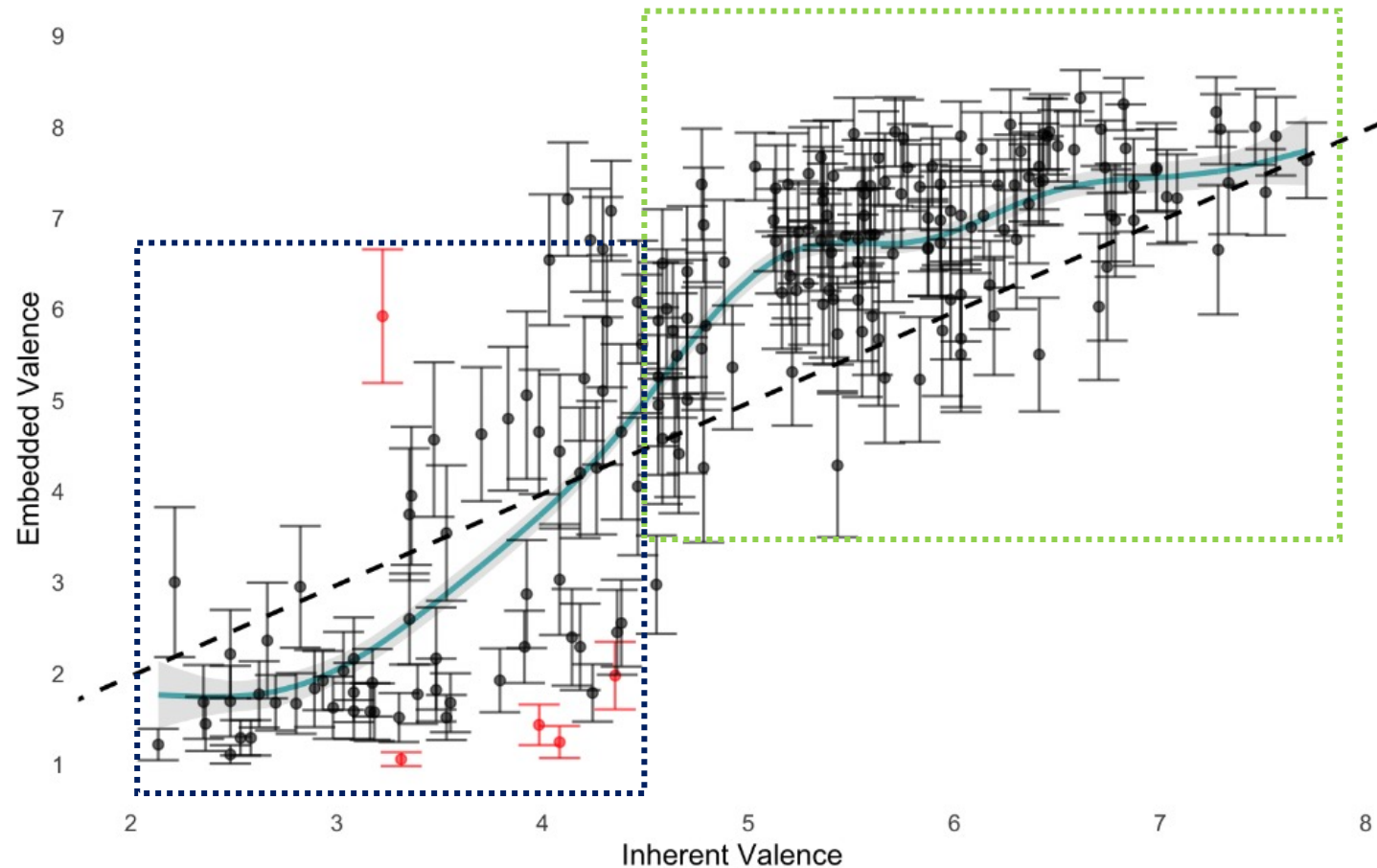
(5) “The EA NOUN” (Paper 3, Study 1)

(6) “What a NOUN!” (Paper 4, Study 2)

EAs: Negative Valence Appraisals



Wh-Exclamatives: Polarity-Based Valence Appraisals



RQ3:

**Contextual Emotion Cues
and Expressive Behavior**

Expressive Adjectives

- **EAs can be resolved flexibly** (e.g., Frazier et al. 2015; Gutzmann, 2019; Bross, 2021; Donahoo et al., 2022; Ronderos & Domaneschi, 2023)

(7) The waiter has spilled the damn coffee.

😞 The waiter

subject-reading

😞 The coffee

object-reading

😞 The waiter spilling the coffee

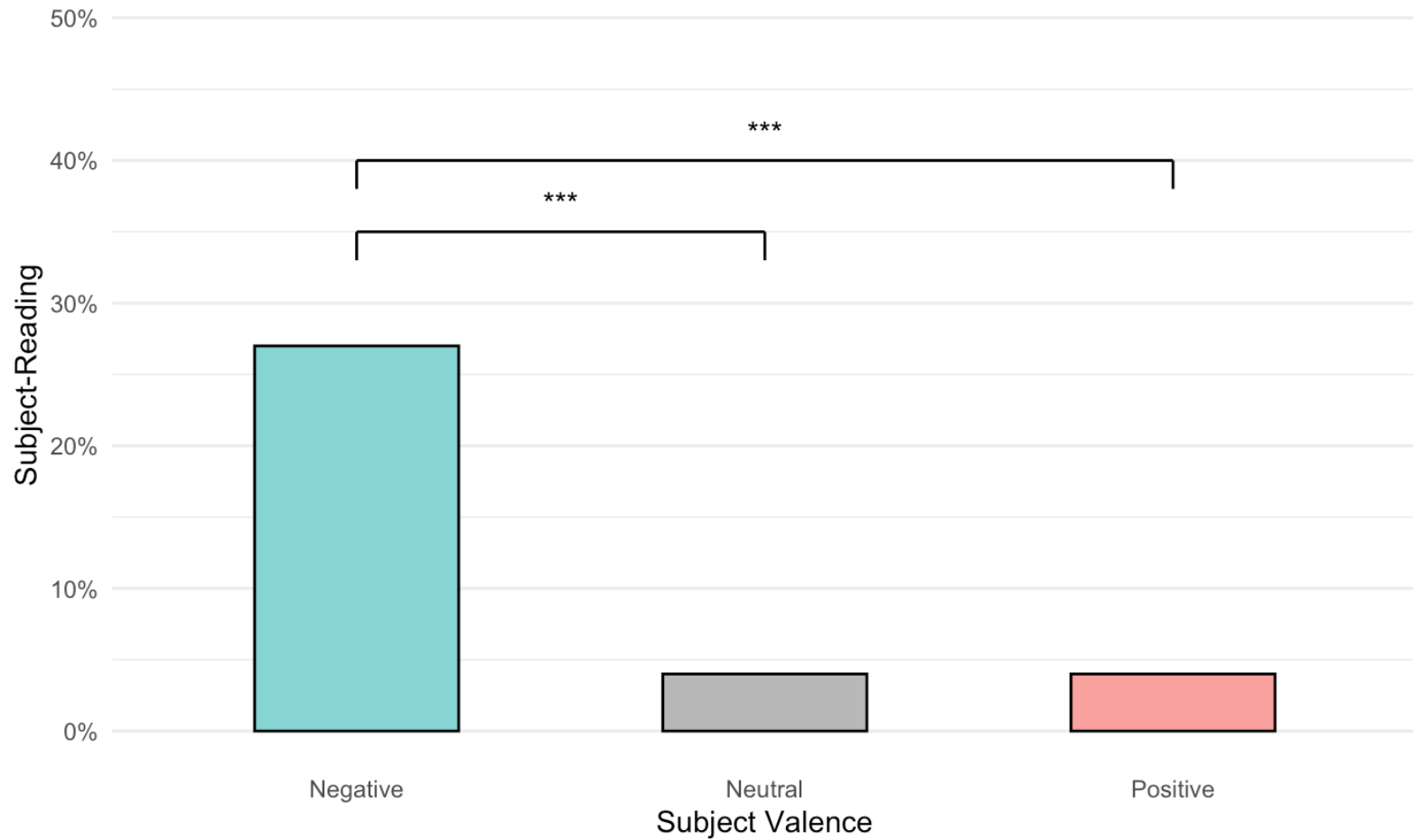
event-reading

Contextual Valence and EA Resolution

- **Prediction:** EAs preferentially target most negative discourse referent
- **Measure:** EA resolution in sentences with differently valenced referents

(8) The [thief|waiter|gentleman] has seen the damn teacher. (Paper 1, Study 3)

Referent Valence and Pure-EA Resolution



Mixed EAs

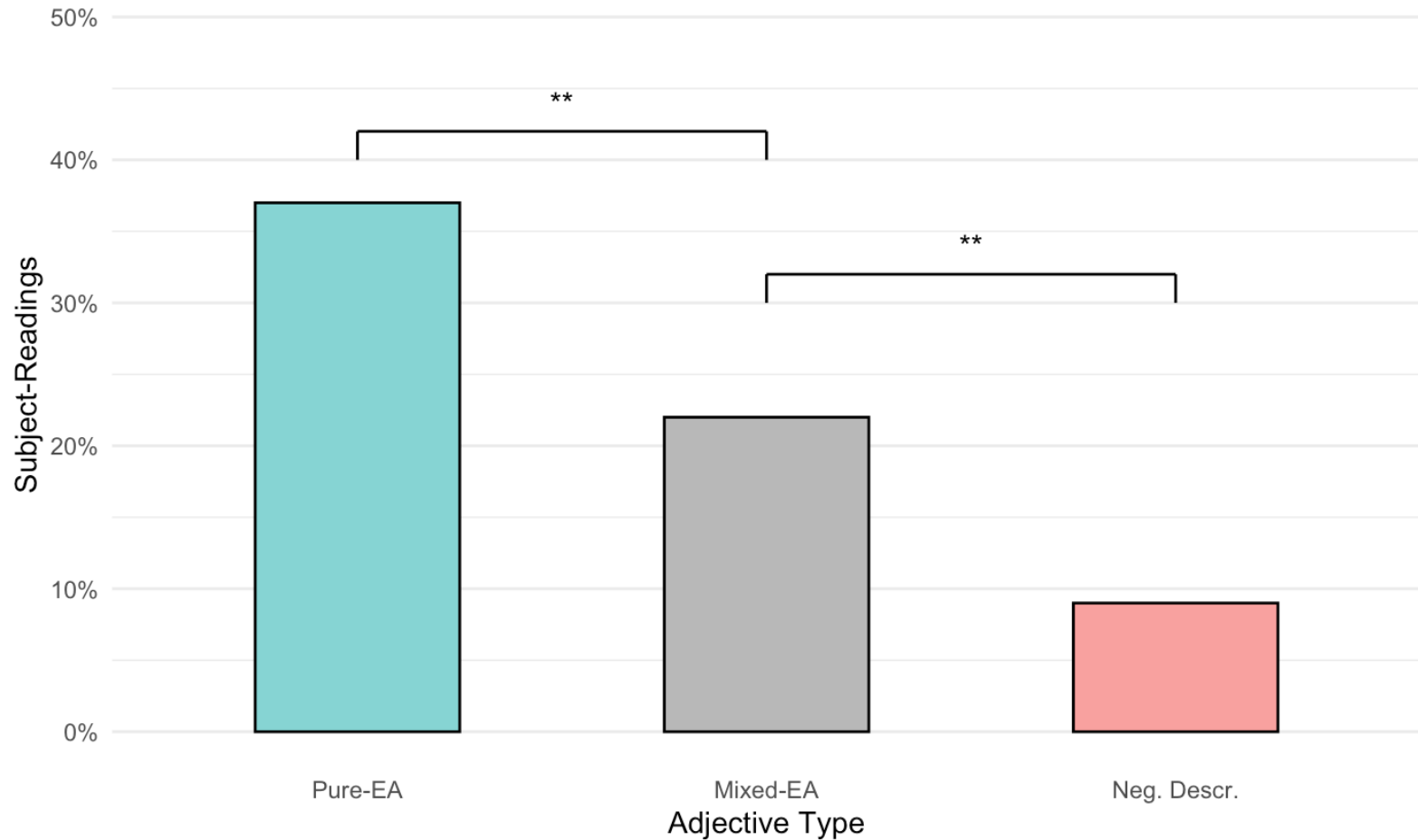
- Mixed EAs encode both descriptive and expressive meaning (e.g., Gutzmann, 2015; Gutzmann & Turgay, 2025; Bross, 2025)
- (9) The waiter has spilled the damn coffee.
- (10) The waiter has spilled the shitty coffee.
- (11) The waiter has spilled the very bad coffee.
- Descriptive meaning of EAs negativizes contextual valence of local referent

Contextual Valence and Mixed EAs

- **Prediction:** Higher probability of non-local readings for pure EAs than for mixed EAs than for negative descriptive adjectives
- **Measure:** EA resolution in sentences with differently valenced referents

(12) The customer screamed at the the [damn|shitty|very bad] waiter. (Paper 1, Study 3)

Referent Valence and Mixed-EA Resolution



Conclusion

Advantages of Valence-Based Approach

1. Cognitively grounded and interdisciplinary
2. Parsimonious
3. Applicable to most expressive phenomena

Thank you for your attention!